



SPRFMO

South Pacific Regional Fisheries Management Organisation

Jack Mackerel Working Group

Benchmark meeting report 2026

May 19, 2026

Summary

This is a starter draft for the 2026 Jack Mackerel Working Group benchmark meeting report. It is structured to capture the main workshop decisions, agreed recommendations, unresolved technical issues, and follow-up tasks needed to support the June 2026 management strategy evaluation workshop and subsequent Scientific Committee review.

The benchmark meeting is expected to focus on assessment inputs, abundance-index evaluation, biological data and assumptions, assessment-model simplification, operating-model conditioning, and priorities for the MSE work programme. This draft should be updated during the workshop as sessions conclude, with short decision text and action items added while technical discussions are still current.

Meeting Details

- Meeting: JMWG benchmark meeting 2026
- Date: 18-22 May 2026
- Location: Lima, Peru
- Organisation: South Pacific Regional Fisheries Management Organisation
- Working group: Jack Mackerel Working Group
- Host: Peru / IMARPE
- Chair: Jim Ianelli
- Meeting format: Primarily in person, with selected remote participation as arranged

Opening of the Meeting

The Chair opened the meeting and welcomed participants to the 2026 benchmark workshop. The Chair noted that the workshop has a practical purpose: to convert a large set of technical contributions into clear benchmark priorities, model-input decisions, and follow-up tasks for the JMWG and MSE process.

The Chair emphasized that the benchmark material contains many sensitivities, including stock structure, index selection, catchability and availability, effort creep, selectivity, recruitment assumptions, biological inputs, and operating-model conditioning. The workshop should focus on which sensitivities materially affect advice, operating-model conditioning, and MSE readiness.

Members were encouraged, to the extent practical, to supplement technical presentations with concise information on data extent, including years covered, spatial coverage, fleet or survey coverage, observation unit, sample sizes, treatment of missing data, and whether uncertainty is available for assessment use.

The Chair also noted that work sessions and report-writing time are part of the technical work of the meeting. Each session should aim to leave behind short text on decisions, unresolved issues, data requests, and recommended follow-up.

Adoption of Agenda

The meeting reviewed the draft agenda and agreed to organize the week around acoustic indices, CPUE indices, biological inputs, assessment-model development, projections, operating-model specifications, and final report adoption. A shortened agenda is provided in Appendix A.

Workshop Objectives

The main objectives of the benchmark meeting are to:

1. Review and document candidate abundance indices and their suitability for assessment use, operating-model conditioning, and possible management-procedure input.
2. Review biological inputs, including maturity, natural mortality, weight-at-age, length-weight relationships, and length-frequency information.
3. Review the SC13 assessment base model and candidate simplifications for benchmark and MSE use.
4. Identify a defensible set of assessment-model alternatives, sensitivity runs, and diagnostics.
5. Define operating-model conditioning priorities and uncertainty dimensions for the June 2026 MSE workshop.

6. Document decisions, unresolved technical issues, and follow-up responsibilities in the meeting report.

Organization of Work

The meeting work should be organized around technical sessions and smaller drafting or analysis groups. Where possible, each major topic should produce:

- a short decision statement;
- a list of accepted inputs or candidate inputs;
- a list of sensitivities or diagnostics to run;
- data or documentation requests;
- text that can be inserted directly into the final workshop report.

For contributors who are not working directly in GitHub, use Google Docs as the collaborative drafting layer and keep this Quarto report as the source of record. The recommended workflow is described in the [Report Collaboration Workflow](#).

Key Discussion Summary

Acoustic Indices

The Day 1 acoustic session combined formal SCW16 working papers with presentation-only material. The presentations covered the history of the north-central Chile acoustic survey programme, preliminary 2026 survey results, oceanographic conditions during the 2026 survey, spatio-temporal standardization of acoustic backscatter, fishery-dependent acoustic information, Peruvian acoustic assessment information, sonar applications relevant to jack mackerel and anchoveta fisheries, and acoustic information collected by fishing vessels in Peru.

For reporting purposes, the presentation material should be separated into four categories: formal papers tied to numbered SCW16 documents, presentation-only background, new 2026 evidence, and context or supporting methods. This distinction is important because not all Day 1 material is intended to become a direct assessment input. Some presentations provide candidate abundance indices, while others provide survey context, environmental interpretation, diagnostic information, or methodological background.

A Day 1 presentation crosswalk is provided in Appendix D. That table should be updated as presenters confirm titles, authors, and whether each presentation should be cited as a working paper, supporting presentation, or meeting-record item.

i New draft material: Day 1 acoustic session summary

The meeting noted that many working papers and presentations analysed important abundance-index data, but did not consistently document the extent of the data used in each analysis. This limited the group's ability to evaluate representativeness, sample support, survey coverage, and whether uncertainty was adequately propagated. Members were requested to provide concise metadata for each candidate index or supporting analysis, including years covered, spatial extent, survey or fleet coverage, observation unit, number of observations or transects, number of biological samples or tows, expansion methods, whether lengths are fork length or total length, and the uncertainty available for assessment use.

For the north-central Chile acoustic survey programme, the meeting requested a summary table giving, by year where possible, the number of transects, area covered, number of trawls or biological samples used to interpret backscatter, available length-frequency information, and how biological samples were expanded. This table is needed to compare the 2024-2026 surveys against earlier years and to distinguish changes in abundance from changes in survey extent or data support. Members also requested clarification of the table presented for the 2026 survey, particularly the distinction between total survey area, area containing jack mackerel, NASC density, and biomass-related quantities.

The historical review of hydroacoustic surveys in north-central Chile emphasized large interannual changes in jack mackerel distribution. Participants discussed whether the recent decline and distribution in 2026 resembled earlier periods, including 1997 and the years when jack mackerel were not detected in one or more surveys. The meeting noted that the 2003-2004 period involved movement away from the survey area and that 2010 marked a return of fish to the survey area. The 2026 information suggested a different recent pattern, with limited movement from the open ocean towards the coast and an increased presence of juveniles in northern coastal areas relative to recent years.

The preliminary 2026 Chile acoustic results raised questions about vertical distribution, detectability near the surface, and school structure. The meeting noted that a high proportion of individuals was observed in the upper 30 m in 2025 and 2026, but that participants did not identify a survey dead-zone issue for these observations. Participants discussed whether fish close to the surface or more dispersed schools could affect detectability. The presentation indicated that fish were more dispersed in 2026 than in 2025 and that acoustic-trawl operations were most effective around dawn, when jack mackerel tended to concentrate.

The oceanographic presentation proposed that large jack mackerel may have moved offshore and dispersed in response to reduced coastal food concentration associated with ENSO-related inhibition of coastal upwelling. The meeting noted that this hypothesis should be compared directly with the acoustic observations, because some survey evidence appeared to suggest coastal or near-coastal concentrations rather than offshore displacement. The report should therefore treat the oceanographic explanation as a working hypothesis that requires reconciliation with the acoustic distribution, chlorophyll-a information, and

fishery-dependent observations.

Two spatio-temporal acoustic standardization approaches for northern Chile were reviewed. The `sdmTMB` acoustic-density analysis based on NASC used zero-included spatio-temporal modelling and was presented as a complementary index. The meeting discussed whether the Tweedie model adequately captured the very high proportion of zeros, whether the survey design and spatial mesh could absorb abundance signal, and how uncertainty in extrapolated areas should be carried through to the final index. Participants cautioned that summing median predictions across areas may understate uncertainty if spatially extrapolated cells are weakly informed. The INLA-based northern Chile analysis used acoustic information converted to biomass with biological data, and participants discussed the roles of occurrence, positive density, anisotropy, and environmental covariates. The meeting noted that these two acoustic products use related data and should be compared for complementarity, redundancy, uncertainty, and sensitivity to survey coverage.

The fishery-dependent acoustic presentation for south-central Chile was viewed as potentially useful but not yet ready for direct assessment use without further work. Participants noted the high temporal resolution and lower cost of commercial-vessel acoustic information, but also discussed preferential sampling, changes in fishing behaviour, possible technology effects, seasonal shifts, and correlation with CPUE from the same fleet. The meeting discussed whether fishery-dependent and fishery-independent acoustic data could eventually be combined, but noted that the fishery-dependent product may be more appropriate as a diagnostic or future sensitivity until the effects of seasonality, vessel coverage, fleet behaviour, and sampling design are better understood.

For the Chile central-south acoustic survey series, participants requested a short paragraph explaining why the historical central-south acoustic data have not been used in the assessment in recent years, including specific reference to available survey years such as 2012, 2015, 2017, 2020, 2021, and 2023. The paragraph should state whether the exclusion is due to survey design, data quality, representativeness, inconsistency with other indices, model behaviour, or lack of documentation, and whether any sensitivity run should be considered for the benchmark.

The Peruvian acoustic discussion emphasized that the acoustic survey programme was primarily designed for anchovy, and that jack mackerel may occur outside the surveyed area in some years. Participants discussed the large decline after the 1997/1998 El Niño event, possible ecological regime changes, changes in spatial distribution from nearshore to more offshore areas, and whether the existing Peru acoustic series in the assessment adequately reflects those changes. The meeting requested Peruvian acoustic survey backscatter data and associated length composition data, including survey timing, spatial extent, transect coverage, biological sampling, length type, and uncertainty. The meeting also noted that summer and winter surveys may need to be treated separately because seasonal differences and contrasting within-year values may contain useful information. The sonar and fishing-vessel acoustic presentations provided methodological context rather than immediate assessment inputs. Sonar may improve information on presence, school

behaviour, swimming direction, and fish outside the echosounder beam, but was not considered ready to provide quantitative biomass estimates for jack mackerel. Fishing-vessel acoustic data in Peru may provide useful context, but additional work is needed to understand juvenile avoidance, vessel behaviour, calibration, and how fishery-dependent acoustic observations relate to fishery-independent survey information.

The meeting identified a need for a dedicated analysis that compares acoustic survey extent, backscatter, biological sampling, length-frequency data, and numbers-at-age across years and regions. This analysis should include northern Chile, central-south Chile, Peru, and fishery-dependent acoustic products where available. The objective is to determine which acoustic information is suitable for direct assessment likelihood use, which is suitable for operating-model conditioning or management-procedure diagnostics, and which should remain supporting context.

Day 1 Requests

The following requests were identified during the Day 1 acoustic session and should be tracked separately from general discussion notes.

Request	Requested product	Lead / source	Purpose
Data extent for all index analyses	For each acoustic and CPUE analysis, provide years covered, spatial extent, fleet or survey coverage, observation unit, sample sizes, treatment of missing data, uncertainty, and expansion method.	All index contributors	Allow the benchmark to evaluate representativeness, data support, and suitability for assessment, OM conditioning, or MP use.
Presentation/report summaries	Each technical discussion should leave short report-ready text summarizing decisions, unresolved issues, data requests, and follow-up tasks.	Session leads / rapporteurs	Keep the benchmark report current enough to support intersessional Scientific Committee approval and the June MSE workshop.
Public access to presentations	Clarify whether presentations can be made available to the full Scientific Committee.	Secretariat / presenters	Ensure the Scientific Committee can review the evidence base supporting benchmark recommendations.
Chile north acoustic survey metadata	Provide a table by year, where possible, with number of transects, area covered, number of trawls or biological samples used for backscatter interpretation, length-frequency data, and expansion information.	Chile acoustic contributors	Compare 2024-2026 survey data extent with previous years and evaluate survey support for candidate acoustic indices.

Chile north acoustic table clarification	Clarify the distinction between total survey area, area containing jack mackerel, NASC density, and biomass-related quantities in the presented survey table.	Chile acoustic contributors	Avoid confusion between survey domain, occupied area, density, and biomass interpretation.
Chile central-south acoustic exclusion rationale	Draft a paragraph explaining why central-south acoustic data, including 2012, 2015, 2017, 2020, 2021, and 2023, have not been used in the assessment and whether a benchmark sensitivity is warranted.	Chile acoustic / assessment contributors	Document whether exclusion is due to survey design, representativeness, data quality, model behaviour, or insufficient documentation.
Cross-year acoustic data comparison	Prepare a dedicated analysis comparing survey extent, backscatter, biological sampling, length-frequency data, and numbers-at-age across years and regions.	Acoustic/index subgroup	Put northern Chile, central-south Chile, Peru, and fishery-dependent acoustic products on a common evidence basis.

Peru acoustic backscatter and length composition	Provide acoustic survey backscatter and associated length-composition data, with metadata on survey timing, spatial extent, transect coverage, biological sampling, length type, and uncertainty.	Peru acoustic contributors	Evaluate whether Peru acoustic information can be used as an index, sensitivity, OM input, or diagnostic.
Peru acoustic assessment treatment check	Check current assessment treatment of the Peru acoustic index, including selectivity, catchability, CV assumptions, relationship to Peru CPUE, and possible pre-/post-1997/1998 treatment.	Assessment subgroup	Determine whether the current model treatment is defensible and whether reintroduction or split-index treatment should be tested.
Chile central-south acoustic sensitivity	Evaluate whether updated central-south acoustic data through 2023 should be included as a sensitivity or retained as diagnostic information.	Assessment subgroup / Chile contributors	Decide whether unused central-south acoustic information should be tested in the benchmark model set.

CPUE Indices

The Day 2 CPUE session reviewed catch and fishery data quality checks, Chilean effort-creep correction, spatio-temporal Chilean CPUE standardization using **sdmTMB** and INLA-based approaches, Peruvian CPUE standardization, and offshore CPUE treatment. The discussion focused on whether candidate CPUE products are ready for assessment use, what additional diagnostics are needed, and how to document any change from the current assessment CPUE treatment.

i New draft material: Day 2 CPUE session summary

The catch and fishery data quality-check presentation emphasized that the JMWG has historically worked under a compressed assessment-data schedule. Members noted that the current data-submission templates and associated processing routines are pragmatic tools for meeting that schedule, and that development of Secretariat database infrastructure would not by itself resolve the immediate benchmark needs. The meeting requested that the quality-check work be posted to the `jjmData` GitHub repository, and that the group clarify how members use terms such as sampling, coverage, and sample size. In particular, the meeting requested checks on the age-length-key sample-size reporting to identify discrepancies between reported numbers of ages and numbers of length measurements.

The Chilean effort-creep presentation showed that the number of active industrial vessels has declined while average hold capacity has increased over time. Participants discussed whether applying the creep factor as an effort correction is equivalent to imposing a catchability change, and whether the survey/interview information used to estimate creep can be maintained regularly. The meeting also noted that the artisanal fleet now accounts for a larger share of Chilean catch and may need to be considered in future effort-creep work. As a diagnostic, the meeting requested a model run with no creep correction but with a catchability step change in 2005, to evaluate whether the assessment estimates a large catchability shift without imposing the creep correction directly.

For the Chilean `sdmTMB` CPUE analysis, the meeting noted that the index was updated through 2026 and is based on set-level data. Discussion focused on haul capacity treatment, the use of a spline smoother versus vessel categories, the large imbalance in early-year data coverage, and whether true zero catches are available and should be incorporated. Participants noted that the early part of the set-level data may represent a very small fraction of total catch, raising questions about representativeness before about 2005. The meeting requested that the data table include the number and proportion of sets by year, and that the authors provide a clear explanation for why the new set-based CPUE series gives lower CPUE in earlier years with high catches than the current trip-based assessment series.

The INLA-based Chilean CPUE analysis provided a complementary spatio-temporal standardization. Participants discussed mesh resolution, the treatment of northern fishing activity, whether assessment fleets should be defined primarily by area or vessel behaviour, and whether CPUE weighting should be based on catch rates rather than catch. The meeting noted that the model appeared sensitive to data updates, with inclusion of 2026 data changing earlier predictions, and that this sensitivity needs to be explained before replacing the existing assessment index. Participants also discussed fixed versus random year effects, AR(1) versus independent year effects, and the interpretation of the days-at-sea or DFP coefficient. Because offshore movement can increase days at sea without necessarily indicating reduced abundance, the meeting requested that the strength and interpretation of this coefficient be checked, and that Sebastian, Ignacio, and Niels summarize the model-comparison and year-effect discussion for the report.

The meeting did not reach a final decision on replacing the current Chilean CPUE series. The group needs a defensible explanation for any move from the current trip-based index to a new spatio-temporal set-based index, including how early low coverage, model sensitivity, year-effect treatment, northern fishing activity, catchability, and annual standard errors would be handled in the stock assessment. If a new Chilean CPUE product is carried forward, the assessment model should use the annual uncertainty estimates from that analysis.

The Peruvian CPUE presentation covered a standardized CPUE series for 2015-2025 that combines industrial and artisanal fleets. The meeting noted this combined fleet treatment as a strength, but also discussed the interpretation of trip locations, haul-capacity and distance-to-coast smoothers, possible differences between industrial and artisanal fleet effects, and changes in Peruvian fishing operations. Members noted that jack mackerel has been used for direct human consumption in Peru since 2002, and that the artisanal fishery has accounted for a larger share of the quota since 2019. The updated CPUE series does not yet extend back far enough to evaluate the full historical period, and extension to earlier years is expected later in 2026. The meeting therefore noted that the benchmark cannot make a final decision on using the new Peru CPUE series for the June 2026 MSE work, because the full time series will not be available for evaluation until later. The meeting requested additional diagnostics, including the smoother on the year interaction, before deciding whether and how the new series could be linked with the older Peru CPUE and acoustic information.

The offshore CPUE discussion included the treatment of a catchability break in 2021 associated with movement of the offshore fleet to the north, and discussion of how El Nino effects were represented relative to annual effects. The report should document the rationale for any offshore catchability break and whether environmental effects are interpreted as catchability effects, availability effects, or residual year effects.

Day 2 Requests

The following requests were identified during the Day 2 CPUE and data-quality session and should be tracked separately from general discussion notes.

Request	Requested product	Lead / source	Purpose
Catch/fishery data workflow statement	Draft a paragraph explaining the JMWG's compressed data schedule, the current template-based submission routine, and why database development alone will not resolve near-term benchmark data needs.	Data-quality subgroup / Chair / Secretariat	Document why the current workflow is used and what should be improved without disrupting immediate assessment preparation.
Post data-quality checks	Post the catch and fishery data quality-check material to the <code>jmwData</code> GitHub repository.	Data-quality subgroup	Make diagnostics and checks visible to members working on assessment inputs.
Clarify sampling and ALK sample sizes	Investigate reported sample sizes in age-length-key and composition data, including discrepancies between numbers of ages and numbers of length measurements.	Data-quality subgroup / Members	Improve interpretation of sample size, coverage, and uncertainty in composition inputs.
Effort-creep diagnostic run	Run an assessment configuration with no creep correction but with a catchability step change in 2005.	Assessment subgroup / Chile CPUE contributors	Test whether the model estimates a large catchability shift without directly imposing the effort-creep correction.

Chile CPUE early-period explanation	Provide a clear explanation for why the new set-based CPUE series gives lower CPUE in earlier years with high catches than the current trip-based assessment index.	Chile CPUE contributors	Support any defensible recommendation to replace, supplement, or retain the current Chile CPUE index.
Chile CPUE set coverage	Add number and proportion of sets by year to the CPUE data-summary table.	Chile CPUE contributors	Document representativeness and low early-period coverage.
Chile CPUE model-comparison summary	Summarize the sdmTMB and INLA model-comparison discussion, including year-effect treatment, mesh sensitivity, northern fishing activity, and annual uncertainty.	Sebastian / Ignacio / Niels	Provide report-ready text for deciding whether a new Chile CPUE index can be used in the assessment.
Days-at-sea coefficient check	Check the strength and interpretation of the days-at-sea or DFP coefficient in the INLA-based CPUE analysis.	Sebastian / Chile CPUE contributors	Determine whether this covariate reflects fishing effort, spatial availability, or movement effects that could bias the abundance signal.
True-zero CPUE records	Check whether zero CPUE records are true fishing zeroes or technical/non-fishing records, and whether they should be included in the CPUE standardization.	Chile CPUE contributors	Decide whether positive-only models are adequate or whether zero-inflated/delta treatment should be evaluated.

Peru CPUE full-series evaluation	Extend and evaluate the Peru CPUE time series before using it as an assessment or MSE input.	Peru CPUE contributors / Assessment subgroup	Avoid adopting a truncated recent series before its relationship to the historical series can be evaluated.
Peru CPUE year-interaction diagnostic	Provide the smoother or effect plot for the year interaction in the Peru CPUE model.	Peru CPUE contributors	Help evaluate whether spatial or fleet changes are being absorbed by model smoothers.
Offshore CPUE catchability treatment	Document the rationale for the 2021 offshore catchability break and the interpretation of El Nino effects relative to annual effects.	Offshore CPUE contributor / Assessment subgroup	Clarify whether offshore CPUE changes represent abundance, catchability, availability, or environmental effects.

Biological Inputs

Text to be added during the meeting. This section should summarize biological assumptions and data inputs, including maturity, natural mortality, weight-at-age, length-weight relationships, length-frequency composition data, and implications for assessment and operating-model conditioning.

Assessment Model Development

Text to be added during the meeting. This section should summarize the SC13 base-model developments, candidate simplifications, single-stock and two-stock alternatives, reduced-index configurations, selectivity assumptions, recruitment scenarios, and model diagnostics.

Operating Models and MSE Linkages

Text to be added during the meeting. This section should summarize operating-model specifications, reference-set and robustness-set uncertainties, MCMC feasibility, management-procedure input diagnostics, and workflow needs for the June 2026 MSE workshop.

Decisions and Agreements

Add agreed decisions here as the meeting proceeds.

No.	Decision or agreement	Topic	Follow-up needed
1	TBD	TBD	TBD

Action Items

Add actions here as the meeting proceeds.

Action	Lead	Support	Target timing
Update the participant list and affiliations	Chair / Secretariat	Members	During meeting
Maintain session-level report text as discussions conclude	Session leads	Rapporteurs / participants	Daily
Prepare a final index-ranking table for candidate abundance indices	Assessment/index subgroup	Acoustic and CPUE contributors	Before report adoption
Prepare an operating-model uncertainty table for MSE conditioning	MSE subgroup	Assessment subgroup	Before report adoption
Provide data-extent metadata for each acoustic and CPUE analysis, including years, area, observation units, sample sizes, survey or fleet coverage, biological samples, uncertainty, and expansion methods	All index contributors	Secretariat / rapporteurs	Before report adoption

Action	Lead	Support	Target timing
Prepare a north-central Chile acoustic data-extent table with transects, area covered, trawls or biological samples, length-frequency data, and expansion information by year	Chile acoustic contributors	Assessment/index subgroup	Before report adoption
Draft a paragraph explaining why the Chile central-south acoustic survey series has not been used in the assessment, and whether any benchmark sensitivity should be run	Chile acoustic contributors	Assessment subgroup	Before report adoption
Provide Peru acoustic backscatter and associated length-composition metadata, including survey timing, spatial extent, length type, biological sampling, and uncertainty	Peru acoustic contributors	Assessment/index subgroup	Before report adoption
Compare acoustic survey extent, biological sampling, length-frequency data, and numbers-at-age across northern Chile, central-south Chile, Peru, and fishery-dependent acoustic products	Acoustic/index subgroup	Chile and Peru contributors	Before final index recommendations

Action	Lead	Support	Target timing
Check current assessment treatment of the Peru acoustic index, including selectivity, catchability, CV assumptions, relationship to Peru CPUE, and whether pre-/post-1997/1998 treatment should be considered	Assessment subgroup	Peru contributors	Before model-run decisions
Evaluate whether updated Chile central-south acoustic data through 2023 should be included as an assessment sensitivity or retained as diagnostic information	Assessment subgroup	Chile contributors	Before final model-run list
Draft text on the JMWG's compressed data-submission workflow and post catch/fishery data quality-check material to the <code>jmwData</code> repository	Data-quality subgroup	Chair / Secretariat	Before report adoption
Investigate age-length-key and composition-data sample-size reporting, including discrepancies between numbers of ages and numbers of length measurements	Data-quality subgroup	Members	Before biological-input decisions

Action	Lead	Support	Target timing
Run an assessment diagnostic with no Chilean effort-creep correction but with a catchability step change in 2005	Assessment subgroup	Chile CPUE contributors	Before CPUE index decisions
Add number and proportion of sets by year to the Chile CPUE data-summary table	Chile CPUE contributors	Assessment/index subgroup	Before CPUE index decisions
Prepare report-ready text explaining differences between the current trip-based Chile CPUE and the new set-based spatio-temporal CPUE products, especially in early high-catch years	Chile CPUE contributors	Sebastian / Ignacio / Niels	Before CPUE index decisions
Check the strength and interpretation of the days-at-sea or DFP coefficient in the INLA-based Chile CPUE analysis	Chile CPUE contributors	Assessment/index subgroup	Before CPUE index decisions
Check whether zero CPUE records are true fishing zeroes or technical/non-fishing records and whether zeroes should be included in Chile CPUE standardization	Chile CPUE contributors	Assessment/index subgroup	Before final model-run list

Action	Lead	Support	Target timing
Extend and evaluate the Peru CPUE time series before deciding whether it can be used as an assessment or MSE input	Peru CPUE contributors	Assessment subgroup	Before future benchmark/model updates
Provide the year-interaction smoother or effect plot for the Peru CPUE model	Peru CPUE contributors	Assessment/index subgroup	Before final CPUE recommendations
Document the rationale for the 2021 offshore CPUE catchability break and the interpretation of El Nino effects relative to annual effects	Offshore CPUE contributor	Assessment subgroup	Before final model-run list

Open Issues / Risks to Track

- Some candidate indices may have useful contrast but unresolved representativeness, catchability, availability, or uncertainty issues.
- Acoustic and CPUE information may give conflicting recent signals, requiring clear documentation of interpretation and model-treatment choices.
- Model simplification for MSE tractability must be balanced against structural assumptions that members view as scientifically important.
- Biological inputs may differ by area, fleet, season, or stock hypothesis, and may require explicit sensitivity tests.
- Report writing must keep pace with the technical discussion so that decisions are not lost before adoption.
- Several acoustic and CPUE analyses currently lack enough data-extent metadata to evaluate representativeness and sample support.
- Peru acoustic information may contain useful historical and seasonal signal, but its assessment use depends on survey coverage relative to jack mackerel distribution, biological sampling, and possible pre-/post-1997/1998 changes.
- Fishery-dependent acoustic products may add spatial and seasonal information, but preferential sampling, fishing behaviour, technology effects, and correlation with CPUE

must be evaluated before direct assessment use.

- The current data-submission workflow is expedient but depends on consistent interpretation of sampling, coverage, and sample-size fields across members.
- The Chilean effort-creep correction may be confounded with catchability changes, and the assessment consequence should be tested before accepting the correction as a base input.
- A switch from the current trip-based Chile CPUE series to a set-based spatio-temporal series requires a clear explanation of early-period coverage, model sensitivity, year-effect treatment, northern fishing activity, and annual uncertainty.
- The Peru CPUE series is currently too short for June 2026 MSE use because the full historical extension has not yet been evaluated.
- Offshore CPUE catchability breaks and environmental effects need clear interpretation so that abundance, availability, and fishing-behaviour changes are not conflated.

Appendix A. Shortened Draft Agenda

This appendix summarizes the draft agenda from SCW16-Doc00. It should be updated if the adopted meeting agenda differs materially.

Day 1: Acoustic Session

- Opening ceremony, official photo, and meeting organization.
- Historical review of hydroacoustic survey programs in north-central Chile.
- Preliminary results of the 2026 north-central Chile hydroacoustic survey.
- Oceanographic conditions during the 2026 acoustic survey.
- Spatio-temporal modeling of acoustic backscatter from the north-central Chile survey.
- Toward a standardized northern Chile acoustic abundance index.
- Opportunistic acoustic data collection from the south-central Chilean commercial fleet.
- Review of jack mackerel acoustic assessments conducted in Peru, including SCW16-Doc16.
- Use of acoustic data collected by fishing vessels for estimating abundance/biomass in Peru.
- Echogram examination and validation.
- General discussion and technical recommendations.

Day 2: CPUE Session

- Metadata by fleet and country.
- CPUE methods by fleet and country.
- Peruvian CPUE report, including SCW16-Doc15.
- Comparative analysis and parsimony across candidate indices.

- Effort-creep review and decision for stock assessment use.
- Catchability and availability blocks by abundance index.
- CPUE weighting factors for stock assessment.
- Separate versus combined index products for HCR or management-procedure use.

Day 3: Recap, Report Drafting, and Biological Inputs

- Recap of acoustic and CPUE sessions.
- Drafting of index-session report text and follow-up tasks.
- Summary of SCW16-Doc01 and benchmark-model implications.
- Review of biological assumptions used in the assessment and operating models.
- Review of Peru length-weight and length-frequency information, including SCW16-Doc13 and SCW16-Doc14.

Day 4: Projections, Recruitment Scenarios, and Operating Models

- Assessment projections and recruitment scenarios.
- Candidate assessment-model runs and sensitivity structure.
- Operating-model specifications for MSE conditioning.
- MCMC evaluations, convergence diagnostics, run-time constraints, and feasibility.

Day 5: Final Decisions and Report Adoption

- Final benchmark decisions and recommendations.
- Confirmation of model-run priorities, operating-model specifications, and follow-up tasks.
- Report drafting, review, and adoption.

Appendix B. Participants

This participant list is based on the registration information available at the start of the benchmark meeting. Email addresses are retained outside this public report.

Name	Delegation	Role	Organisation / agency	Format
Jose Ignacio Zenteno Loredó	Chile	Advisor	IFOP	In person
Aquiles Sepulveda	Chile	Advisor	INPESCA	In person

Name	Delegation	Role	Organisation / agency	Format
Qi Lee	Invited Expert	Invited Expert by SPRFMO	University of Washington	In person
Niels Teon Hintzen	European Union	Expert	PFA	In person
Karolina Molla Gazi	European Union	Designated Representative / HoD	Wageningen Marine Research	In person
Jim Ianelli	JMWG Chairperson	Expert / Chair	NOAA	In person
Victor Catasti	Chile	Expert	IFOP	In person
Ignacio Paya	Chile	Expert	IFOP	In person
Sebastian Vazquez	Chile	Expert	INPESCA	In person
Nicolas Alegria	Chile	Expert	INPESCA	In person
Nicole Mermoud	Chile	Designated Representative / HoD	SUBPESCA	In person
Ana Alegre Norza Sior	Peru	Designated Representative / HoD	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Criscely Lujan Paredes	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Mirian Geronimo	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Aparicio Gersson Roman	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Amancio Erich Diaz	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Acuna Josymar	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Torrejon Daniel Isaias	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Grados Paredes	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Carlos Valdez Mego	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Marissela Pozada Herrera	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	In person
Mariano Sergio Gutierrez Torero	Peru	Expert	Instituto Humboldt	In person

Name	Delegation	Role	Organisation / agency	Format
Salvador Peraltilla Neyra	Peru	Expert	Sociedad Nacional de Pesqueria	In person
Sandra Marisol Cahuin Villanueva	Peru	Expert	Instituto del Mar del Peru	Virtual
Iago Mosqueira	Expert	Expert	WUR	Virtual
Teobaldo Dioses	Peru	Expert	GMAIL	In person
Jaime Letelier	Chile	Expert	IFOP	TBD
Esteban Molina	Chile	Expert	IFOP	TBD
Francisco Leiva	Chile	Expert	IFOP	TBD
Javier Legua	Chile	Expert	IFOP	TBD
Jorge Castillo	Chile	Expert	IFOP	TBD

Appendix C. Document Summary by Topic

This appendix summarizes SCW16-Doc01 through SCW16-Doc16. The organization is by topic rather than document number so that related evidence can be reviewed together.

Assessment and Model Structure

Developments of the Base SC13 Model

[SCW16-Doc01](#) documents benchmark development from the SC13 JJM assessment model, including single-stock and two-stock configurations, reduced-index sensitivities, selectivity alternatives, and model diagnostics. It is the main bridge between the current assessment model and the benchmark model set.

Key report use: summarize accepted base-model structure, candidate simplifications, retained sensitivities, and any model configurations to carry into OM conditioning.

Operating Models and MSE

Operating Models for Jack Mackerel MSE

[SCW16-Doc04](#) describes the operating-model structure for jack mackerel MSE. It should be used to organize reference-set and robustness-set uncertainties, including stock hypotheses,

recruitment assumptions, selectivity, catchability, and future projection structure.

Key report use: define the operating-model grid or equivalent uncertainty table that will feed the June 2026 MSE workshop.

CPUE

CPUE Coordination Priorities and Working-Paper Plan

[SCW16-Doc02](#) provides the forward-looking CPUE coordination plan for the benchmark, including candidate topics, decision points, metadata needs, and working-paper expectations.

Key report use: structure the CPUE session and make sure each candidate CPUE product is classified for assessment, OM conditioning, MP input, diagnostic use, or hold.

Meta-Analysis of CPUE Papers on Jack Mackerel

[SCW16-Doc03](#) synthesizes CPUE papers from 2022-2025. It provides historical context on CPUE methods, index conflicts, effort creep, spatial behavior, environmental effects, and recurring recommendations.

Key report use: provide background for interpreting new CPUE papers and avoid repeating previously identified unresolved issues.

Chile CPUE Effort Creep

[SCW16-Doc07](#) focuses on implementation of an informed creep correction for the Chilean jack mackerel CPUE index. It is central to decisions about fishing-power correction and whether a revised CPUE series should be used directly or treated as a sensitivity.

Key report use: document whether effort-creep treatment is accepted, treated as a sensitivity, or deferred pending additional diagnostics.

Chile CPUE with sdmTMB/SPDE

[SCW16-Doc10](#) updates the Chilean CPUE abundance index using spatio-temporal SPDE-based models with **sdmTMB**. It should be compared directly with other Chilean CPUE standardization approaches.

Key report use: evaluate whether the spatio-temporal CPUE product should replace, supplement, or diagnose the current assessment CPUE series.

Chile CPUE with INLA

SCW16-Doc12 standardizes the central-southern Chile CPUE fishery using hierarchical Bayesian models with INLA. It provides a complementary spatio-temporal approach to Doc10.

Key report use: compare diagnostics, uncertainty, spatial extrapolation, and annual index behavior against the **sdmTMB** CPUE product.

Peru CPUE

SCW16-Doc15 presents standardization of catch-per-unit-effort for jack mackerel from 2015-2025 in Peruvian national jurisdictional waters.

Key report use: evaluate whether the Peruvian CPUE product is suitable as a far-north abundance index, an assessment sensitivity, an OM-conditioning input, or a diagnostic series.

Acoustic Indices

Northern Chile Acoustic Spatio-Temporal Model

SCW16-Doc06 develops a standardized abundance index for Chilean jack mackerel using spatio-temporal modeling of acoustic survey data in northern Chile.

Key report use: evaluate acoustic index representativeness, uncertainty, spatial coverage, and suitability for assessment and OM use.

Fishery-Dependent Acoustics

SCW16-Doc08 summarizes interannual variability in distribution, size structure, and biomass estimated from fishery-dependent acoustics.

Key report use: decide whether fishery-dependent acoustic products provide a usable abundance signal or primarily diagnostic/context information.

Central-North Acoustic Density with **sdmTMB**

SCW16-Doc09 estimates a jack mackerel acoustic density index for central-north acoustic surveys using spatio-temporal models with **sdmTMB**.

Key report use: compare with Doc06 and other acoustic products to determine whether indices are complementary, redundant, or conflicting.

Peru Acoustic Index Considerations

[SCW16-Doc16](#) summarizes considerations on the use of the jack mackerel acoustic index in Peruvian national jurisdictional waters.

Key report use: classify the Peru acoustic information as a candidate index, supporting interpretation, or diagnostic evidence, depending on data extent, uncertainty, and assessment compatibility.

Biology and Composition Inputs

Biology

[SCW16-Doc05](#) summarizes biological inputs for the assessment, including natural mortality, maturity, weight-at-age, and spawning-biomass calculations.

Key report use: document accepted biological assumptions and identify sensitivity tests that should be carried into assessment or OM conditioning.

Peru Length-Weight Relationship

[SCW16-Doc13](#) presents the length-weight relationship of jack mackerel in Peru and implications for biomass estimation.

Key report use: evaluate whether Peru-specific length-weight information affects biomass conversion, biological assumptions, or regional differences in assessment inputs.

Peru Length-Frequency Update

[SCW16-Doc14](#) summarizes updated length-frequency data for the Peruvian jack mackerel far-north stock in Peruvian jurisdictional waters.

Key report use: document the composition-data evidence available for the far-north stock and decide how it should be used in assessment and stock-structure discussions.

Data Quality and Supporting Evidence

Catch/Fishery Data Quality Checks

[SCW16-Doc11](#) provides catch and fishery data quality-control checks.

Key report use: use as a support screen for catch- and fishery-dependent indices, and document any data-quality issues that affect benchmark decisions.

Appendix D. Day 1 Presentations

This appendix records the Day 1 presentation files available in `docs/day1`. It is intended as a crosswalk between the acoustic-session agenda, formal SCW16 papers, presentation-only material, and how each item should be used in the meeting report.

Presentation topic	Linked paper	Main contribution	Report use
Historical review of hydroacoustic survey programs in north-central Chile	Presentation only	Survey-program history, continuity, and context for interpreting the northern Chile acoustic time series.	Background / context
Preliminary results of the 2026 north-central Chile hydroacoustic survey	Presentation only; related to Chile acoustic index papers	New 2026 acoustic information and immediate interpretation of recent survey conditions and abundance signal.	New 2026 evidence / benchmark caveat
Oceanographic conditions during the 2026 acoustic survey	Presentation only	Environmental context for interpreting the 2026 survey and potential availability or distribution effects.	Context / supporting interpretation
Spatio-temporal modeling of acoustic backscatter using sdmTMB	SCW16-Doc09	Acoustic density index estimated with spatio-temporal methods.	Formal paper / candidate index
Standardized northern Chile acoustic abundance index	SCW16-Doc06	Spatio-temporal modelling of northern Chile acoustic-survey data.	Formal paper / candidate index
Opportunistic acoustic data collection using the south-central Chilean commercial fleet	SCW16-Doc08	Fishery-dependent acoustic information on distribution, size structure, and biomass.	Formal paper / diagnostic or candidate index

Presentation topic	Linked paper	Main contribution	Report use
Review of jack mackerel acoustic assessments conducted in Peru	SCW16-Doc16	Peruvian acoustic assessment context and considerations for index use.	Formal paper / supporting evidence or candidate index
Sonar applications in Peruvian fisheries and applicability for jack mackerel	Presentation only	Methods and operational context for sonar/acoustic information in Peru and Chile.	Context / supporting methods
Acoustic data collected by fishing vessels in Peru	Presentation only	Use of fishing-vessel acoustic data for estimating abundance or biomass of anchovy and Chilean jack mackerel in Peru.	Context / supporting methods

Use the following labels when carrying presentation material into the report:

Label	Meaning
Formal paper	Presentation tied to a numbered SCW16 working paper.
Presentation only	Material presented to the meeting but not currently represented by a numbered SCW16 paper.
New 2026 evidence	Recent information that may affect benchmark interpretation even if it is not a standalone paper.
Context / supporting methods	Background or method information that helps interpret candidate indices but is not itself a direct assessment input.